

Jeffrey Bickish — Music Career Roadmap

Acoustic Folk | Sandpoint, Idaho | 3–5 Year Plan to Part-Time Income

Overview

This plan is built around your current strengths — original catalog, home recording setup, and prior performance experience — with a realistic ramp to **\$1,000–\$2,000/month** in part-time music income over 3–5 years. Working 4–8 hours per week, the strategy prioritizes **local gigs as the fastest income path**, while online platforms (YouTube, streaming, sync licensing) build as long-term passive income layers.

Key advantage: Sandpoint is a tourist-driven resort town with a strong outdoor/folk culture and seasonal demand for live acoustic music — restaurants, breweries, events, and Schweitzer-adjacent venues are natural early targets. Vocal training completes ~July 2026, making summer 2026 your natural launch window.

The Four Phases

PHASE 1 Foundation & Launch Months 1–6 April – Sept 2026 Time Focus: Split across practice, setup, and first gigs	Key Goals: • Complete vocal training (target: July 2026) • Record and release first single via DistroKid (\$22/yr) • Launch website (Squarespace/Bandzoogle), email list (MailerLite free) • Set up Instagram, YouTube, TikTok with consistent handle • Do 3–5 open mics to rebuild local performance comfort • Book 2–4 paid gigs for summer tourist season (\$100–\$200/gig) • Start posting 1 short video/week (cover or original song clip) Income Sources: • Live gigs: \$100–\$300/gig solo acoustic • Tip jar at open mics • Streaming: near zero (just building)
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PHASE 2

Build Presence & Catalog

Months 7–18 | Oct 2026 – Sept 2027

Time Focus: Heavier on content creation and gig booking

Key Goals:

- Record and release debut EP (4–6 songs, home studio)
- Establish 2–3 regular monthly gigs (restaurants, breweries, private events)
- Grow YouTube to 200–500 subscribers with consistent uploads
- Build email list to 100–300 local + online fans
- Apply to 2–3 regional summer festivals (Treefort, NW Folk, local fests)
- Post weekly on Instagram Reels/TikTok — short song snippets perform best
- Set up simple merch (stickers, digital downloads)

Income Sources:

- Live gigs: \$400–\$800/month (2–4 gigs)
- Streaming micro-income: \$10–\$50
- Digital downloads/merch: \$0–\$100
- Tip links (Venmo QR at shows, link in bio)

PHASE 3

Expand & Monetize

Year 2–3 | 2027–2028

Time Focus: Shift time toward income-generating content and regional reach

Key Goals:

- Reach YouTube monetization (1K subs + 4K watch hours)
- Submit to sync licensing platforms: Musicbed, Artlist, Pond5
- Expand to Coeur d'Alene, Spokane gig circuit (1–2x/month)
- Record second EP or full-length album
- Launch Patreon or 'buy me a coffee' monthly supporter model
- Start offering 3–5 online guitar/songwriting lessons/week (\$50–75/hr)
- Pitch corporate/private events (weddings, dinners) at higher rates

Income Sources:

- Live gigs (local + regional): \$600–\$1,400
- YouTube AdSense: \$50–\$200
- Sync licensing: \$100–\$300
- Online lessons: \$100–\$400
- Streaming + merch: \$50–\$200

PHASE 4

Sustain & Scale

Year 3–5 | 2028–2030

Time Focus: Income now multi-stream; protect creative time

Key Goals:

- Consistent Pacific Northwest regional touring (Bozeman, Missoula, Portland)
- YouTube channel as ongoing discovery engine (3K–10K+ subs)
- Annual album or EP release cycle
- Licensing catalog growing passively
- Email list 500–1,000+ — most valuable long-term asset
- Consider licensing music for local film, ads, podcasts
- Evaluate whether to stay part-time or go deeper

Income Sources:

- Live gigs (local + regional): \$800–\$1,200
- YouTube AdSense: \$150–\$400
- Sync licensing passive: \$200–\$500
- Online lessons: \$200–\$600
- Streaming + merch + fan support: \$100–\$300

Income Projection by Source

These ranges are realistic based on how acoustic folk artists in small resort markets typically grow. Live gigs dominate early income; online sources become meaningful in years 2–3.

Income Source	Year 1	Year 2	Year 3	Year 4-5
Local Gigs (Sandpoint)	\$0–\$400	\$400–\$800	\$600–\$1,000	\$800–\$1,200
Regional Gigs	\$0	\$0–\$200	\$200–\$400	\$400–\$600
Streaming (Spotify/Apple)	\$0–\$10	\$10–\$50	\$50–\$150	\$100–\$300
YouTube AdSense	\$0	\$0–\$50	\$50–\$200	\$150–\$400
Sync Licensing	\$0	\$0–\$100	\$100–\$300	\$200–\$500
Online Lessons	\$0	\$0	\$100–\$400	\$200–\$600
Merch + Fan Support	\$0	\$0–\$50	\$50–\$150	\$100–\$200
TOTAL ESTIMATE	\$0–\$400	\$400–\$1,200	\$1,150–\$2,600	\$1,950–\$3,800

* Ranges assume consistent 4–8 hrs/week effort and seasonal Sandpoint gig market.

How to Allocate 4–8 Hours Per Week

Activity	Hours/Week	Notes
Writing, practicing, recording	1.5–3 hrs	Core creative work

Activity	Hours/Week	Notes
Content creation (YouTube/social)	1–2 hrs	Short clips, 1 YouTube video/2 weeks
Booking, outreach, admin	0.5–1 hr	Email venues, respond to inquiries
Gigging (when booked)	2–4 hrs	Travel + performance (bonus hours)

Recommended Tools & Platforms

Category	Tool / Platform	Why
Music Distribution	DistroKid (~\$22/yr)	Gets you on Spotify, Apple Music, YouTube Music
Website	Bandzoogle (\$10/mo)	Built for musicians, includes store + email list
Email List	MailerLite (free to 500)	Simple, clean, free tier is plenty to start
YouTube	YouTube Studio	Highest long-term ROI for folk/acoustic content
Social Media	Instagram + TikTok	Short original clips — algorithm-friendly for folk
Sync Licensing	Musicbed / Artlist / Pond5	License your recordings for passive income
Fan Support	Bandcamp + Venmo QR	Bandcamp is beloved by folk fans; zero barrier
Booking / Press	Sonicbids or direct email	Festivals and venues often use Sonicbids
Online Lessons	Zoom + TakeLessons.com	TakeLessons handles discovery + scheduling

Sandpoint-Specific Strategy

Sandpoint's small population (~9,000) is offset by significant tourist traffic, a strong arts community, and year-round events. Key opportunities:

- **Summer peak (June–Aug):** Highest demand for live music — restaurants, patios, Farmers Market, outdoor events near City Beach
- **Schweitzer area (winter):** Après-ski acoustic sets, lodge bookings (\$150–\$300/set)
- **Local breweries & wine bars:** Evans Brothers, MickDuff's, Pend d'Oreille Winery — regular live music rotations
- **Private events:** Weddings, corporate retreats, lakehouse gatherings — highest per-gig income (\$300–\$800)
- **Festivals:** Sandpoint Music Festival, Lost in the '50s, Oktoberfest — apply 3–6 months in advance
- **Regional day trips:** Coeur d'Alene (30 min) + Spokane (1.5 hrs) open circuit for years 2–3

Reality Check

At 4–8 hours/week, the path to \$1K–\$2K/month is realistic but not fast. The honest timeline is **3–4 years** for consistent income at that level. A few factors that will determine your pace:

- **Consistency beats hustle:** 5 steady hours/week outperforms 20 hours one week and nothing for three
- **Live gigs are your fastest return:** Even 2 gigs/month at \$150–\$250 each = \$300–\$500 in year 1
- **Online income takes time:** Streaming pays almost nothing until you have tens of thousands of listeners
- **Your Sandpoint advantage:** Small-town reputation builds fast — one great show leads to three more bookings
- **Email list over followers:** 200 email subscribers who love your music are worth more than 2,000 Instagram followers